

CEREAL

ALONG WITH A COMPLETE BREAKFAST, PROVIDES ESSENTIAL VITAMINS, MINERALS AND SHORT STORIES!

Hypothermia

A sound like a fly repeatedly flying into a windowpane accompanied the flashing of the red neon sign. "Donuts... Donuts... Donuts..." Ethel was wiping the front counter down. It didn't really need it, but no one had been in for hours, and she needed to keep busy. It passed the time. Her eyes were on the task she had made for herself, but she wasn't seeing the rag or the damp arcs it left on the counter. She was sipping from a lifetime's cup of recollection. She felt there was no present for her. She thought of herself in the past tense. The Diet Pepsi clock told her it was nine; she knew that meant it was nearly 5:AM. Two hours left to her shift, and then she could sleep-- two hours that she knew would feel like years, and that would be remembered like seconds. The furrows on her forehead deepened: she was tired of yesterdays. In the back, a nagging buzz announced the donuts. The sight of them bobbing new-tanned in boiling oil was all too familiar. More familiar than her own face in the mirror; when she thought of herself, she saw herself when her hair was still a raven black cascade, before her blue eyes were buried in wrinkles, before the liver spots discolored her hands. How had she ended up like this? But she had stopped asking questions years ago. Perhaps she didn't want to know the answers. They could do her no good, for she was here. She had been here for years, and nothing

by Jason Paul
Fox

could change that. It was time to glaze the donuts. Why are the signals so harsh in such places? Better not to ask. The door jangled, and he was there. She

tried not to, but she remembered him. She remembered the fumbling in the drive-in, the sense of stealing a secret and forbidden pleasure, the desperate quest for something nameless before the

emotional hypothermia set in. She perhaps understood it all less now than she had then. She remembered necking hours through on the porch swing,

struggling to suppress her sighs, to keep them from reaching her parents overhead-losing time until, too late, she realized he had left, that he wasn't coming back. And her mother, and her grandmother, seemed to beckon from their graves, whispering their ghostly histories. And she would never discover what she had needed, and she could never go back. When she looked up again, he was half-gone, packing his Winstons on a wrist, his face

bland, worn and leathery. There was no sign if he recognized her, and suddenly she wasn't sure it was him after all. As he climbed into the ancient pickup truck parked out front, her eyes underwent some sort of change-- it was like fireflies winking out at twilight. The neon glow washed her pale, careworn face with its brutally impersonal red light, and the donut buzzer rang.



KAFKA GETS LAID

Waking from deepest slumber, eyes still shut, Kafka drinks the cognac of retreating sleep. He pulls the heavy blanket tight about him and buries his face in the pillows. He hears the play of water in the bath. _ Yes, that will do, Kafka thinks. Morning stillness. Dappled light. The sounds of another soul serene in the adjoining room. Two minds with an interval to consider what their bodies have wrought. _ Kafka opens his eyes and turns to the window. The curtains billow. Perfect scene. She has been in there, what?, twenty-five, thirty minutes? He turns to the door. Gretchen will be flesh and blood today, he thinks. Not a woman who, after an all-night tumble, strains his thigh and announces she is an apparition before disappearing at dawn.

She was a clerk at the bank where Kafka went to make his weekly deposit. From his place in line he watched her smile shyly when customers spoke to her, averting her gaze if they made her laugh. A girl really, twenty-one or twenty-two, yet she seemed so unapproachable in her high collar with the ivory buttons, that he never dared ask her to dinner.

For a year Kafka tried to melt her shy severity

with witty remarks as she stamped his checks with a crack and tallied the entries in her massive ledger. She had told him her name and that she had come from the countryside, and that is all Kafka knew.

BY
DAVID HOZEL

One evening in early spring they came upon each other in the market. The magazine had unexpectedly purchased one of his stories and, with a few crowns jingling in his purse,

Kafka was in a gay mood. He enjoyed her surprise as they rounded an onion stall from opposite sides.

"What are you doing here?" she said.

Kafka answered before he could laugh, "Buying onions."

Her hair was not tied tight in the usual manner, but fell loosely around her shoulders. Without her ledger and the iron bar that separated her from the customers, Gretchen's shyness had no sanctuary. Kafka watched her chest heave.

"Will you have supper with me, Gretchen?"

Before she could gather an excuse he made her agree to immediately accompany him to what he promised was a restaurant of mystery just a short ride away. Facing her for the first time, Kafka

noticed how slender her shoulders and hips were. Her boyish frame reminded him of Berta, with whom he had an affair the year before. Whereas Berta's breasts were small, Gretchen's tightly laced bodice indicated something more voluptuous, although Kafka was unable to calculate to what degree.

Berta had pretensions of being a writer. They met at a party hosted by a garrulous, but unsuccessful publisher of Kafka's acquaintance. He found Berta in the corner of the publisher's drafty sitting room, smoking cigarettes and holding forth on her plans to make literature conform to the aesthetics of the machine age.

"Who would read a book printed on sheet metal in which every page repeats the one before it?" Kafka asked after listening a few moments.

"In five years workers will be so much like machines that they will welcome a literature that reflects their experience," Berta answered and bit her thin lips.

She did not invite him home that night. But within a week their affair had begun. Kafka soon adopted her habits, eating little except when invited to dinner parties, sleeping in the afternoon, still awake at dawn planning a novel without verbs. He enjoyed their conspiracy of the artist.

Later, he discovered that for all of Berta's pretensions, she wrote little. Her attic room was squalid. He often

found her there, entertaining friends who would ask Kafka for money and never repay it. Her love-making increasingly seemed to be modeled on the machines she so triumphed. He now found coarseness in her candidness, bitterness behind her sharp questions and strong opinions.

One day she announced their affair was ended with the unexceptional explanation: "The magic is gone." It was true, but her artlessness pained him. Now though, as the cab slowed to a halt, the sight of Gretchen's slender form and the association with Berta that it caused warmed Kafka like brandy.

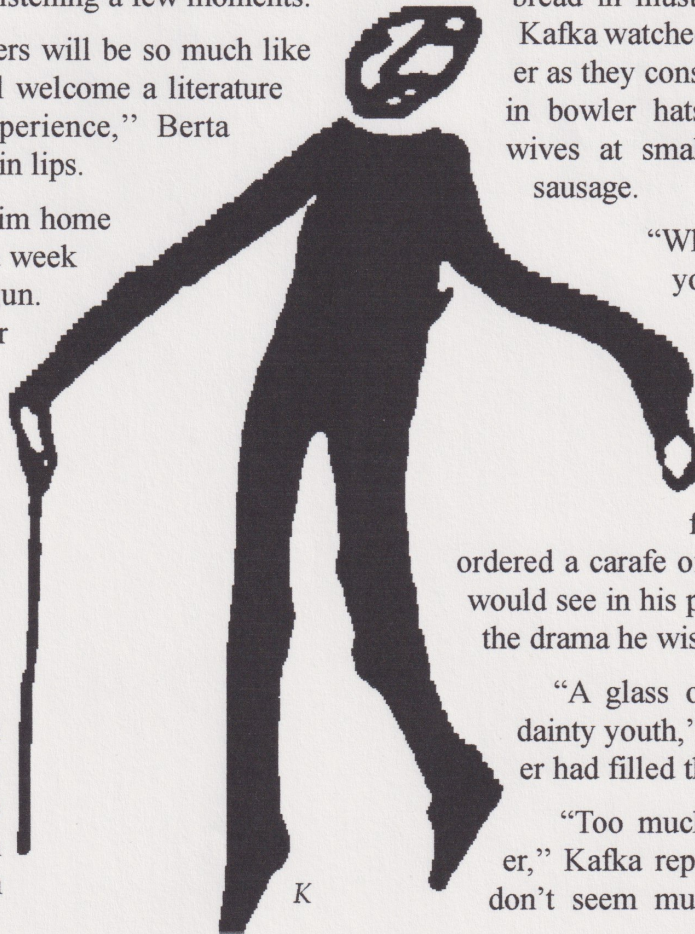
The orchestra was playing as they entered the restaurant. Revolutionaries in torn gray jackets smoked cigarettes and dipped heels of bread in mustard pots. In the mirror, Kafka watched them lean close together as they conspired. Further on, clerks in bowler hats sat across from their wives at small tables and dined on sausage.

"Where is the mystery that you promised?" Gretchen said as they were shown a table in the recesses of the restaurant.

"You must wait for it," Kafka replied. He ordered a carafe of wine, hoping Gretchen would see in his presumption a flourish to the drama he wished them to enter.

"A glass of wine is a woman of dainty youth," she said when the waiter had filled their glasses.

"Too much wine, her grandmother," Kafka replied laughing. "But you don't seem much like Helga Stern in



K

'Bitter Embers.' I think in the chapter before she spoke that line to Baron Fassbinder she had already poisoned Herr Glick the lawyer."

"You can relax, I haven't poisoned anyone today," Gretchen said. "But you do remind me of the baron. So perhaps, sir, you could tell me how much wine is too much?"

"One never knows until it's too late."

They finished the carafe before the meal arrived, and in the smoky light Kafka began to discern new details in Gretchen's face. When she laughed her mouth was like Anna's, with broad lips curling around a delightful overbite.

Anna was a nurse. Kafka had come to the hospital to visit a friend who was recovering from surgery. He found Anna in the sickroom, helping the friend from bed to a chair. That done, she left the room, returning a moment later with some medicine.

As Kafka greeted his friend, he watched Anna. Her steadiness in supporting the much larger man contrasted with her ungainly walk once relieved



of that burden. Physically, she was similarly in conflict -- the body of a thin woman in battle with an incipient thickness.

In subsequent visits Kafka spoke to Anna. But it was weeks before she agreed to see him outside the hospital, weeks more before she betrayed any affection for him. Except his writing, this was the most patience Kafka had devoted to anything.



To be continued
next week in CEREAL

David Holzel is a writer and editor living somewhere near Washington, D.C. His webzine, The Jewish Angle (<http://www.mindspring.com/~dbholzel>), tries hard to make sense of this zany world. E-mail David at jangle1@mindspring.com

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CEREAL

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Cereal Magazine

Panic & Revolution in WASHINGTON D.C.

by Brian Barrett

Part III - If I Could Put Lime in a Bottle

(This chapter is only 99% true. However, A large part has been omitted, and one sentence, the eighth sentence from the end to be exact, is fictionalized beyond all possible belief for story continuity and to protect the guilty parties.)

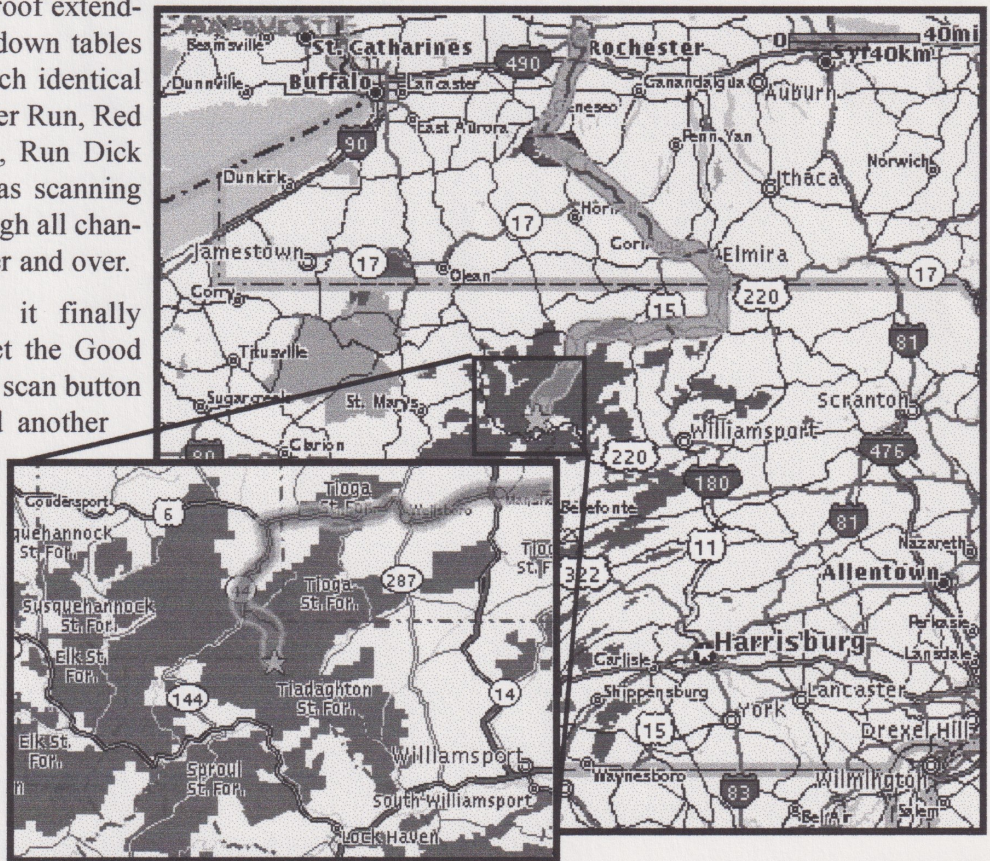
Sixty minutes into Pennsylvania, Jason and I went into a long tunnel through a steep mountain. When we emerged we were in the land of radio silence. Nothing to hear. Nothing to look at but endless road and trees. There were geographical areas in which stood nothing but an occasional shanty bar with a rotted wood roof extending over a couple beaten down tables and the signs that gave each identical landscape a name: Red Deer Run, Red Trout Run, Red Dog Run, Run Dick Run. My digital tuner was scanning the airwaves, cycling through all channels over and over and over and over.

After a few minutes it finally stopped on The Car's "Let the Good Times Roll." I pressed the scan button again. It eventually found another station playing "True Colors" by Cindy Lauper, then another spewing "Saved by Zero" by the Fixx, then another: "Hit Me with Your Best Shot," by Pat Benetar.

"We've must've driven through some sort of time vortex," I concluded, "and have landing in the 80's!"

Jason was skeptical, "Nah, these folks in these small Appellation towns are just backwards."

Coming down the other side of the road was a mint condition LeCar. The driver, a woman with big hair and wearing a bright pink jumpsuit, looked at



my whale-like and streamlined vehicle like it was some type of UFO.

"Ok, backwards, and they love their vintage autos."

I had yet to be convinced.

The radio was warbling: "...And I ran, I ran so far away. I just ran. I couldn't get away..."

"Odds are we didn't go through time," Jason mumbled into the carbon monoxide gas that had built up inside my uninspected, uninsured, and barely safe vehicle.

"There's still the improbable possibility that we did."

"No," He firmly stated with complete conviction just before he passed out amongst the fumes.

I pulled over, destroying three picnic benches that sat outside "Red Bear Run Tavern." I left the windows down, allowed the smoke to settle and dragged Jason inside. The bar was a shack suitable for the next Unabomber. A man of indiscriminate employment and a background that obviously consisted of sitting at the end of this particular bar, was hunched over a mug of beer, watching a baseball game on a 19" inch color television while Johnny Cash sang "I Walk the Line" on a small gray boombox.

I wish I knew something about baseball; something that, with this game, I could confirm the suspected chronological shift. I concentrated, but I couldn't come up with anything other than "Pete Rose, Philadelphia Philly's pitcher, world series, early eighties."

This was not at all useful.

The barkeep came out of the back room. She was

cute, tall and bony and wearing short cut-off jeans and a white half tank-top exposing her smooth stomach. Her long red hair, freckles and her demeanor broadcasted clues that she was not of legal bartending age. She took a step back in surprise when she saw us.

"Howdy! Is there something I can get you gentlemen?" She said the word, "gentlemen," in the sincerity and respect she had given all her elders, even those who, like Jason, were unconscious.

Now was my chance to find out. "You got Fresca?"

"Nope," her eyes twinkled.

"Tab?"

"Sorry," she let out a tiny giggle.

"Like?"

She smiled, leaned forward into the bar, "For pop, we just got Pepsi, 7up, tonic and ginger ale." Her young voice attempted to be sultry, "Are you sure you don't want," she quickly looked me over, "something stiffer?"

I've heard about the charm of these small towns in the middle of nowhere. A city person (and last I checked, Rochester just barely qualified as a city) with all their teeth can come in, hang out for a couple days, find the cutest girl itching to have something more than the Red Bear Run life, and leave with her. It happens at least twenty times a day throughout the country.

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My mind worked past the double entendres and free associated:

stiffer → stiff → rigor mortis → dead → Jason.

He had gotten more CO₂ than me. The passenger window wouldn't come down. Jason's head was still on the counter. I checked to make sure he still had a pulse. She frowned disappointedly as I took a moment to reach for his neck. The beats were weak and slow.

"No, I think we'll just have a breather before we get back on the road."

She poured a couple glasses of ice water. "Where you going?"

"Washington D.C. A convention of librarians. Hang out. Nothing big."

"And where ya from?"

"Rochester, NY" I paused to see some recognition and then continued, "by Lake Ontario. Kodak, Xerox, Bausch and Lomb..." I struggled for more, "White hots..." I pointed at the red glowing sign by the men's room and read, "Genesee."

She looked around and pondered the dark, empty room, illuminated by nothing but beer slogan neon, a single window and a light above the faded green felt of a dilapidated pool table. Her eyes slowly rested on the old man in the corner, still motionless since we arrived. She turned to me, desperately serious and said, "Please, take me with you."

"Hi. I'm Brian." I extended my hand, "What's your name?"

"Sandy," her freckles drowned in her blushing cheeks and she swayed a little as she placed her dainty fingers into my palm.

"Tell me, Sandy, what is today's date?"

"July 28," she smiled broadly with a facial indication that she would remember today for the rest of her life.

I sheepishly asked, "The year?"

She giggled at the absurdity of the question, "1984."

I nudged Jason, who didn't react. I was convinced that I had to save this girl from the late-eighties, the Bush Administration, the upcoming years of metal bands and poorly synthesized pop music. If she was joking, I still had to get her out of this small, one drunk town. I decided, "All right, Sandy, c'mon. Let's go." She jumped up three times clapping her hands in excitement. I added, "Could you help me get my friend to the car?"

She turned to the old man, "Tell Dale I quit, and this time I ain't never ever coming back!"

The man didn't move, didn't say anything, didn't grunt, didn't even change expression.

Jason was a dead weight as he was dragged to the sedan's spacious back seat. I opened the door for Sandy and then slid across the hood in Dukes of Hazard fashion.

"I've never seen a car like this around here," She remarked about the 1991 Caprice Classic.



"It's a cop car from the future."

She giggled, "What year do you come from?"

"1998."

She didn't seem surprised. Maybe she was just joking. Maybe she knew something about time travelers.

The engine started, the radio blasted Springstein's "Born to Run." The car's wheels kicked up dirt until finding a hold on the ground and spun back onto the highway. She took my hand as we headed out of the valley. Yes, together will break this death trap -- this suicide rap. But no matter how confident Bruce was, he faded into static. She leaned forward as to give me a kiss and slowly disappeared into nonexistence.

The white noise static was replaced by a crystal clear Rage Against the Machine, and Jason sat up. He crawled into the pas-

senger seat and situated himself.

Before I could explain what happened, we passed a red-headed woman on the side of the road, hitchhiking, aged by work and child care to beyond her years, overweight and with vacant eyes.

He noticed my sad, thoughtful expression. "Did I miss something?"

It was best he didn't know. All I could say was, "It's too late to save her now." ○○○

*To Be Continued
Next week in
CEREAL:*

**Panic & Revulsion in
Washington D.C.**

**Part IV
Valerie Stardust**

CEREAL **INGREDIENTS**

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